



THE ULTIMATE GUIDE TO MAXIMIZE



LEARN HOW TO:

Maximize your Microsoft
Security investment and ROI

Consolidate your security
stack

Strengthen your security
posture

ABOUT THIS GUIDE

Difenda has partnered exclusively with Microsoft to join forces and revolutionize the way businesses use the Microsoft Security suite of services.

In this guide we explore how to maximize your investment in Microsoft Security to generate more ROI, enable scale, and strengthen your security posture. When you are finished reading, you'll come away with a step-by-step set of instructions for implementing a maximized Microsoft Security game plan for your business.

WHO IS THIS GUIDE FOR?

If you are a security professional who is looking to get more value from your existing Microsoft licensing while reducing the number of tools you manage, this guide is for you.

If your team is spending more time managing multiple security solutions and a high volume of alerts over protecting your environment and data, this guide is for you!

Finally, if you are curious if Difenda can improve your threat detection, response, and overall security posture ... this guide is definitely for you!



WHAT YOU'LL LEARN

- How do I get the highest possible value from my Microsoft Defender for Endpoint investment, deployment, or migration ?
- How do I build a strong foundation with Microsoft Security?
- How do I maximize the value of my investment in Microsoft Security with a Certified Partner?
- What are the Microsoft specific certifications of a fully qualified cybersecurity provider?
- What questions should I ask when evaluating Microsoft Security partners?
- What are best practices integrating compliance with threat protection? What questions should I ask when evaluating MDR providers?
- How do professional services help me get more ROI from Microsoft Security?
- How are others in my industry consolidating their legacy and current security to Microsoft Security?

👉 *Those are a few of the big questions we tackle in this guide.*

Keep reading to learn about how you can maximize the value and revolutionize the way your organization uses Microsoft Security.

Introduction: Why security must be a cornerstone of your digital transformation efforts

Organizations of all sizes are pursuing digital transformation initiatives in order to modernize IT infrastructure, optimize business processes, and gain competitive agility, to name only a few common goals. However, too often, organizations forget to prioritize what should be the bedrock that digital transformation initiatives are build upon: cybersecurity.

Legacy IT systems evolved with security as an afterthought. Although this approach helped accelerate IT initiatives, organizations are now paying the price through daily operations impacting cyber-attacks.

Layering on security after digital transformation will simply modernize the problems we've been coping with for decades. Digital transformation provides the perfect opportunity to shift how security is integrated into information systems and IT infrastructure, and if we fail to prioritize security – again – the impact and costs will continue to grow.

For instance, IBM's and the Ponemon Institute's annual "Cost of a Data Breach Report" reports that the cost of an **average data breach rose from \$3.86 million in 2020 to \$4.24 million in 2021, the highest average total cost in the 17-year history of the report.**

It's not just the cost of a data breach that is on the rise, but the volume and variety of attacks have been steadily increasing, as well. Cloud storage data leaks, ransomware, and business email compromise attacks (BECs), to name only a few threats, are all on the rise.

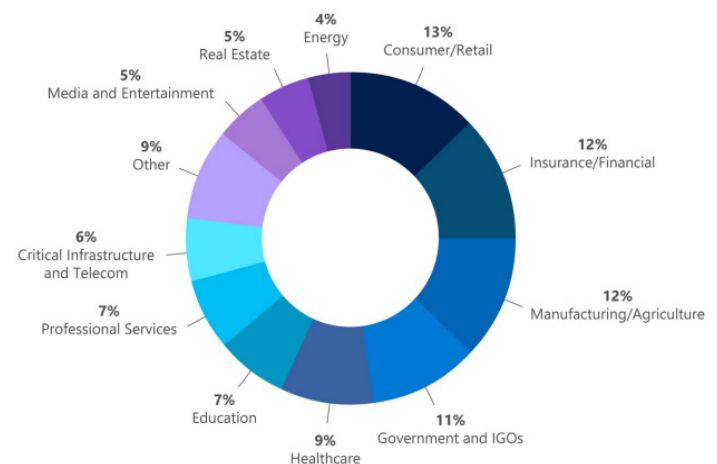
If that's not troubling enough to bring security to the top of your list of digital transformation priorities, consider that attacks from hostile foreign governments, state-sponsored actors, and attacks on critical infrastructure are also skyrocketing.

Events in the news are also driving a rise in threats. The COVID-19 pandemic prompted a spike in phishing and ransomware attacks, while Russia's invasion of Ukraine is prompting renewed concerns about attacks on critical infrastructure, similar to 2021's Colonial Pipeline attack. Russia's invasion is also renewing scrutiny of security tools that may actually serve as beachheads for state actors to launch attacks, such as Russia-based Kaspersky's security solutions.

Even more troubling, research firm Gartner predicts that attackers will soon weaponize critical infrastructure cyber-physical systems (CPS) to harm or kill humans.

With risks rising in both volume and complexity, it's important for organizations of all sizes and in all sectors of the economy to take the steps necessary to protect critical assets from increasingly sophisticated attackers.

DART Ransomware Engagements by Industry (July 2020-June 2021)



HOW MICROSOFT CHANGED THE GAME



If you're reading this guide, you already trust Microsoft for key business-critical tools and systems, and you're looking for the most cost-effective, secure, and scalable way to protect those assets and the data they generate.

Microsoft may not be the first vendor you think of when it comes to cybersecurity, but that's starting to change. The COVID-19 pandemic has accelerated digital transformation efforts across the economy, which has led to a spike in the adoption for cloud services. Some experts believe the pandemic has shortened the usual adoption cycle by seven years or more.

But in the rush to the cloud, security concerns have heightened. In late 2020, a Microsoft survey revealed that:



58% increased their security budgets



82% planned to add security staff



81% needed to lower security costs

That's a tough combination to manage. How does an organization boost security maturity while containing security costs?

If you're already relying on Microsoft platforms, the path to high ROI with your security spend has already been cleared for you. Soon after investing heavily in its Azure cloud platform, Microsoft also saw the need to tightly integrate security

tightly into Azure cloud services, rather than treating it as an afterthought. Microsoft's considerations to securing on-premise workloads and non-Microsoft cloud services, such as AWS and GCP also sets Microsoft Security services apart from other solutions.

As part of their own innovation cycle, Microsoft has invested \$1 billion USD in security development, and that investment is paying off.

Gartner® Magic Quadrant



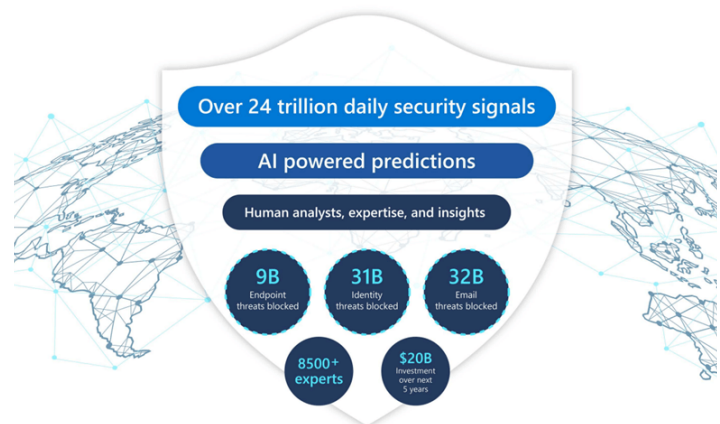
Top-tier industry analysts now rank Microsoft as a leader for a range of security services. Research firm Gartner lists Microsoft as a "leader" in several Magic Quadrant reports, including endpoint protection, access management, CASB, and more.

With Microsoft cybersecurity in place, organizations can now turn to Microsoft's best-in-class security services to protect the other best-in-class business-critical applications and platforms.

Microsoft Security services coupled with a qualified Microsoft partner results in tighter integration, lower TCO, and the ability to deploy best-in-class tools across your cloud platform, be it private, public, hybrid, or even multi-cloud.

MICROSOFT SECURITY SIGNALS

Volume of diversity of signals processed by Microsoft.





How to maximize your Microsoft investment through Certified Microsoft Partners

With Microsoft, you can now secure everything from your cloud assets to critical infrastructure to end points and out to IoT devices and the expanding enterprise edge, with everything secured through well-integrated services.

However, in order to boost security while also lowering costs, most organizations – especially those already heavily invested in Microsoft platforms–would be wise to outsource the heavy lifting of:



Security architecture / roadmap development and deployment



Ongoing management and maintenance of security services



24 x 7 x 365 threat detection and response



Continuous security posture monitoring and enhancements

After all, even if you can find and hire enough security experts, who are scarce and who demand high salaries, to protect all of your digital assets, will those experts be able to keep up with constant patching, ongoing maintenance, and evolving zero-day attacks?

Core tenants of a strong cybersecurity program



Core tenants of a strong cybersecurity program

Managed Detection and Response (MDR)
 Advanced Vulnerability Management (AVM)
 Managed Governance Risk and Compliance (GRC)
 Brand Protection Services (BPS)
 Security Awareness Training (SAT)
 Remote Incident Response (RIR)
 Identity & Access Management
 Information Protection & Governance
 Vendor Risk Management

Smart organizations will instead follow the plans they laid out in their digital transformation strategies and apply them to cybersecurity: focus on your own core strengths and outsource everything else to expert service providers.

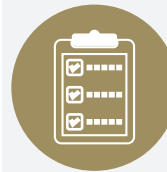
Finding the right service provider, however, can be tricky.

If you're already using Microsoft security products, you want a provider that understands when, where, and how Microsoft security fits into the entire digital value chain. Fortunately, Microsoft has built-in quality controls that ensure that Microsoft Security Partners are up to the task.

Look for Microsoft certification and tiers to ensure best-in-class security services

To ensure that the security partner you choose has been properly vetted, look for security- and cloud-specific certifications, both of which are important when assessing a Microsoft Certified Partner. Microsoft partnership varies by levels of expertise, so be sure to choose a provider that holds a **gold certification** and at least one **advanced specialization** certification to ensure your partner has proven they have the knowledge and have committed the resources necessary to protect assets in the safest manner possible.

Seek a provider that leverages native Microsoft 365 and Azure threat protection services, which incorporates AI, ML, and Microsoft threat intelligence for immediate threat detection. In addition, their services should include third-party integrated threat feeds.



Checklist: Microsoft-specific certifications of a fully qualified cybersecurity provider including:

- Gold Security Certification
- Gold Cloud Platform
- Advanced Specialization – (ex: Threat Protection)
- Microsoft 365 Security Administrator
- Microsoft Azure Fundamentals
- Microsoft Azure Security Engineer Associate
- Microsoft Certified Solutions Associate (MCSA)
- Microsoft Certified Solutions Expert (MCSE)
- Microsoft AZ-300
- Microsoft AZ-500
- Microsoft MS-500
- Microsoft SC-200
- Microsoft SC-300
- Microsoft SC-400
- Microsoft SC-900

Security, compliance, process automation: three key competencies to look for in Security Partners

Advanced security defenses are now table stakes in this fast-moving technology dependent landscape. Your Certified Microsoft Security Partner must be able to help you detect and mitigate threats, meet regulatory requirements, while also helping you control costs through consolidation and automation.

Most vendors will claim to have these capabilities, regardless of their actual level of competence, so how should you differentiate them from other vendors?

Securing your environment is the first step to consider. Many providers will offer a variety of security services, but vendors will differ in their competencies, certifications, partnership levels, and overall approach.

In the next section, we will share eight questions to ask providers during your evaluation period to ensure that security partners can deliver on their promises.



Microsoft Security Partners: 7 key questions to ask providers

1 What Microsoft certifications have you earned and what partnership tiers have you attained?

Microsoft partnership tiers varies by levels of expertise, choose a provider that is a gold security partner at a minimum.

2 What industry certifications do you maintain?

Industry certifications have become mandatory for security service providers, but be sure to do your due diligence. Make sure the provider has earned key certifications, such as PCI DSS, SOC 2 Type II, and ISO 27001. As the US-based CMMC framework emerges, this is another certification that service providers should have within their roadmap.

3 Are you Microsoft Security-focused or do you support multiple security technologies?

Strong Microsoft Security partners will focus their time and energy on the applications, infrastructure, cloud services, and other digital assets that you have invested in, providing protections designed to fully leverage Microsoft services and licensing, from the end point to the cloud to IoT and beyond. On the other hand, vendors who support multi-technology services are less likely to support a well-integrated cost effective delivery model.

Look for a partner that is focused on Microsoft, so that you can take advantage of everything they offer to maximize your investment and properly secure your environment and data.

4 Do you leverage native Microsoft 365, Defender and Azure security services, along with third party intelligence?

Native Microsoft Security services are built on industry leading Microsoft threat intelligence, leveraging advanced machine learning techniques for rapid threat detection and to help protect your environment against zero-day threats. Leveraging third party threat intelligence helps to augment threat detection and hunting capabilities.

5 Are you a part of MISA (Microsoft Intelligent Security Association)?

The MISA ecosystem of independent software vendors and managed security service providers have integrated their solutions in order to better defend against evolving threats. MISA members are vetted by Microsoft, providing additional criteria that can be used to help confirm security service provider capabilities.

6 Do you have the capability to get a higher level of support for customers because of your relationship with Microsoft?

An advantage of working with Gold-level Microsoft Security Partners is that your support concerns will get fast-tracked, and your Microsoft Security Partner will be able to quickly escalate the issue until it is resolved.

7 Are you able to request funding from Microsoft to enable capabilities for your customers and take advantage of the Microsoft security suite of products?

Microsoft incentivizes its Security Partners in order to better attract and serve end users. Has your provider ever secured funding from Microsoft to help their clients get the latest threat protections?



Integrating compliance with threat protection

In today's complex threat environment, it's not enough to simply repel attackers. With security-related regulations on the rise, such as the US DoD Cybersecurity Maturity Model Certification (CMMC), consumer privacy protections in the U.S. (CCPA) and EU (GDPR), organizations must be able to show regulators and auditors that they have the necessary tools and workflows in place to maintain compliance.

Unfortunately, compliance is too often an after-the-fact addition that places heavy labor burdens on compliance teams. When investigating Microsoft Security Partners, be sure to find out whether or not they understand relevant compliance requirements.

A move towards Microsoft Security services is a big step towards laying down a strong compliance foundation. Moreover, if your security partner has gone through the processes necessary to maintain certifications and partnership tiers, they will be trained to get you the rest of the way home when it comes to compliance.

Look for providers that follow processes that are designed with compliance in mind, which means that the processes are, among other things, repeatable, transparent, and auditable. Microsoft has built compliance into its systems, and Certified Microsoft Partners should be able to help you set-and-forget much of the manual, repetitive work of compliance.

Advanced threat capabilities, agile security, and process automation

Digital transformation is about more than technology alone; it also involves the adoption of the agile processes that originated as part of modern software development and expanding those processes, as appropriate, throughout the organization.

Security and compliance are two areas that benefit from agile approaches. However, to be truly agile while protecting digital assets from ever-evolving threats, key processes and workflows must be standardized and repeatable, and, ideally automated. Sticking to traditional manual tactics will almost certainly result in frustrated staff, compliance gaps, and quite likely material security breaches.

Cyber attackers are constantly evolving and continuously switching tactics and techniques. Be sure to vet security partners for advanced capabilities, such the use of Azure Sentinel Fusion machine learning, which not only improves threat protection, but also automate repetitive tasks. These advanced capabilities will help you gain a real-time understanding of evolving threats and will help your organization stay one step ahead of them through advanced multistage attack detection.



Full-spectrum threat protection with Microsoft Defender and Microsoft 365

Finding a Managed Detection and Response (MDR) provider that has an established track record deploying, managing, augmenting, and maintaining Microsoft Security services will help you get the most out of your security budget.

Microsoft Security tools, such as Microsoft 365 Defender, Microsoft Defender for Endpoint, and Microsoft Azure Sentinel, are pushing the envelope on threat detection and response. Microsoft Security is now the leader in five Gartner Magic Quadrants, including access management, endpoint management tools, cloud access, enterprise information archiving, and endpoint protection platforms.

However, skilled security experts are still required in order to get the most out of these new capabilities.

To maximize your Microsoft Security investment, seek out a Microsoft Gold Partner that is highly specialized in Microsoft 365 security service design, implementation, and operations. If you work with any of Microsoft's top global implementation partners, your organization will be in a better position to leverage the full capabilities of Microsoft 365, Defender and Azure security services.

A certified implementation partner will help you not only with design and deployment, but they can help you boost threat detection and response through strong security operations expertise, augmented threat intelligence, and use of advanced concepts such as machine learning.

To find a security partner that checks all of those boxes, look for an MDR provider that can provide:

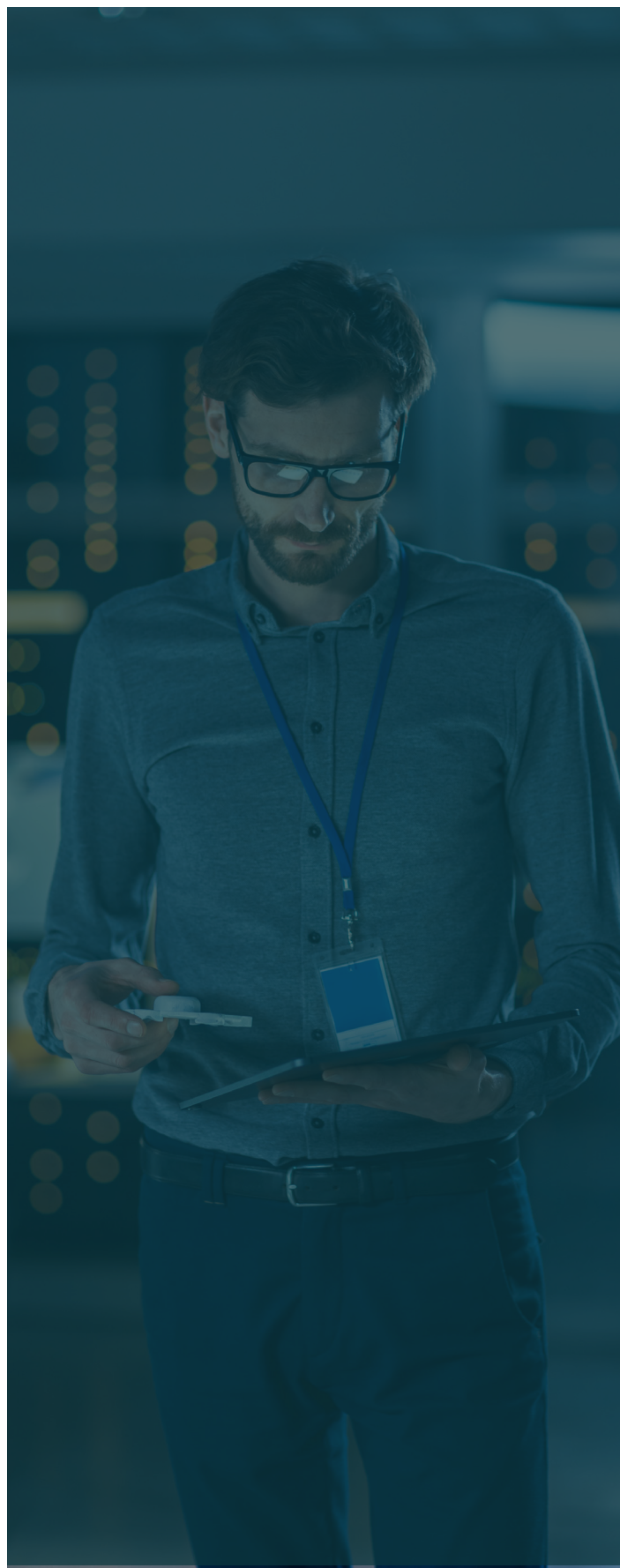
- 24 x 7 x 365 threat detection and response
- Contextualized asset profiling and classification
- Native threat hunting services
- Supplementary threat intelligence services
- Digital forensic and incident response support services
- Centralized service portal-based delivery and reporting





5 questions to ask MDR providers about their security capabilities

- 1 Do you have a robust security operations center (SOC) that is staffed 24x7 with security analysts and incident responders ready to execute on your security playbooks once the service is in place?
- 2 Do you have the capability to manage all the Microsoft 365, Defender (Office 365, Identity, Cloud Apps, Cloud, IoT, etc.), and Azure security services?
- 3 Does your service include asset profiling/ classification, threat detection, threat intelligence, threat hunting, and threat response information all on a single portal?
- 4 Do you leverage both native and custom Defender detections and Azure Sentinel (SIEM) Analytic Rules?
- 5 Do you use advanced Microsoft detection capabilities, such as Azure Sentinel Fusion for multi-stage attack detections?



Professional Services + Microsoft Security: 4 ways to get even higher ROI

Certified security experts will help you run and manage your Microsoft Security service-based security program, but it is also important to find a partner that has the ability to design, implement, and manage all Microsoft 365, Defender, and Azure security services. Roadmap delivery is never “big bang”; security partners must therefore be able to understand security program current state and understand how to incrementally transition to a Microsoft security-centric model.

Moreover, certified experts should be able to keep improving protections over time, helping to not only implement new technologies and features as they become available, but should also identify opportunities to quickly address more material areas of cyber risk.

In addition to identifying quick wins and developing a sound transition roadmap, working with the right Certified Microsoft Security partner will support security simplification and cost reduction. With Microsoft and a competent security service provider, you will be able to develop an effective security consolidation strategy that can reduce risk, simplify security operations, and contain spending.

Finding the right partner will help you boost ROI, while improving protection. Here are four more ways to maximize your Microsoft security investments through professional services:

- 1 Find security experts who will do more than simply offer Managed Detection and Response (MDR) services. Look for experts who know how to design, implement, and support all Microsoft security technologies, and be sure they have the track record to prove it.
- 2 Find a Microsoft Security Partner that is able to not only implement the emerging Microsoft technologies, services, and features, but that is also proficient at augmenting through customer development capabilities (e.g. Analytic Rule and LogicApp development).
- 3 Consolidate your security technologies. Pursue a security consolidation roadmap that incrementally increases cyber resilience, simplifies vendor management and supports program cost containment – from inception to ongoing operations. Look for providers that have previously planned and executed Microsoft Security service transformation programs. A provider that regularly supports customer Microsoft Security journeys will be core to executing your consolidation plan.
- 4 Find a provider that has the ability to scale up security affordably and easily as your security needs and network environment scales up.



The Difenda Difference

Microsoft focused, Microsoft certified, Microsoft trusted

Difenda has provided managed security services to a broad range of clients for more than a dozen years. In 2018, we launched Difenda Shield, our modular cybersecurity platform, and we entered a partnership with Microsoft to align our security offerings with Microsoft's products and platforms.

We are a Microsoft Gold Partner that is highly specialized in Microsoft 365 security service design, implementation, and operations. Difenda also provides customer cyber program support through its Cyber Advisory and Offensive Security services.

Our Difenda Shield platform is designed to provide customers with a streamlined 'SecOps-as-a-Service' experience through highly automated and orchestrated processes based on proprietary integrations with Microsoft 365 services and other supporting industry-leading security technologies.

As a Microsoft Security Gold Partner and a member of MISA, we work closely with Microsoft to innovate new products and add features to existing ones based on real

world customer needs. Difenda's security experts test beta versions of new Microsoft products, help incubate new features in existing products, and suggest new capabilities that help customers stay ahead of the threat curve. As a trusted partner, Difenda is also able to turn to Microsoft to secure funding to help customers integrate Microsoft products.

Simplified licensing and contracts

Difenda works with clients to assess their current technology stacks and offer a phased approach to consolidate or replace bespoke technologies. Based on more than a dozen years of providing managed security services, we at Difenda find the best approach is for customers to retain their own Microsoft licenses.

Retaining your own licenses means that you can maintain full access and control of your environment, and you are not locked into any single security partner. If the level of service is not up to par, the customer gets to decide what to do because it is their license. The job of a managed security provider is not to remove control, but rather to optimize your platform, technologies, and licenses to match the unique needs of your organization.

Advanced cybersecurity capabilities

Our long track record of providing managed security services has allowed us to develop a number of our own innovations that provide even more protection when combined with Microsoft Security products.

Through proactive threat hunting, advanced SOC capabilities, and integrated third-party threat feeds, we are able to detect many attacks quicker to enable clear customer outcomes. These capabilities mean that in the event of an incident, the Difenda team focuses on key metrics such as MTTD (Mean Time To Detect) and MTTR (Mean Time To Respond).

Difenda provides full threat lifecycle management for Microsoft environments. We are experienced at tightly integrating Microsoft environments with outside tools, so you do not have to abandon tools that serve you well.

With Difenda's Managed Detection and Response (MDR), your organization is backed by an elite team of threat hunters and response experts who take targeted actions on your behalf to mitigate even the most sophisticated threats.

IoT and OT protections

As the corporate edge sprawls, it's important not only to secure and protect IoT devices, but also to consider OT (Operational Technology) hardware and software that manages industrial systems and controls critical infrastructure.

As OT and ICS industries move to leaner staffing models and more automated processes, these previously air-gapped systems have come online and must be managed and secured.

Powered by Microsoft Defender for IoT, Difenda's MDR for OT offers turnkey, agentless extended detection and response (XDR). MDR for OT can be rapidly deployed, and

it works to protect a diverse range of endpoints (IoT, OT, and industrial control system (ICS) devices).

The service seamlessly integrates Difenda's MDR-IT and MDR-OT services to provide customers with unified threat protection across the entire environment.

Continuous visibility through Advanced Vulnerability Management (AVM)

Technology advances today at a breakneck pace, but each innovation and upgrade brings new security risks. Each deployment introduces a range of vulnerabilities, interrupts previous data flows, and highlights the need for organizations to maintain constant vigilance.

Difenda AVM offers a strategic approach to vulnerability management that leverages machine learning, business intelligence, and real-time operational and management dashboards that allow remediation teams to focus on and address true areas of risk in technologically complex environments.

Difenda AVM is designed to streamline every core aspect of vulnerability management, including regular vulnerability scans, implementation of secure configuration standards, prioritized remediation of detected vulnerabilities, and deployment of operating system and software patches.

Real-time, unobscured window into our SOC

Every Difenda Shield customer is provided with access to the Difenda Shield Portal, a powerful web-based platform (powered by the leading ServiceNow service management platform) where you can interact with various aspects of threats, make changes to requests, and gain enhanced visibility into your cybersecurity solutions live and on demand.

Difenda provides you with a real-time, unobscured window into our SOC. With Difenda, you are able to automatically pull, store, and report on monitored assets, daily threat events, and service requests.

Governance, Risk, & Compliance

Companies today are overwhelmed by cybersecurity requirements, government mandates, and regulatory frameworks. Many companies find it difficult to maintain a well-organized cybersecurity program that keeps them protected from all angles.

Difenda GRC provides an ongoing effort towards the foundation of your cybersecurity program: governance, risk, and compliance. Our comprehensive suite of services breaks down silos and helps you understand the “why” behind cybersecurity governance, while showing you how best to integrate these rules within your people, processes, and technology.

Difenda powered by Microsoft keeps you protected & compliant in a complex, constantly changing threat environment

As cyber-attacks continue to increase in both kind and complexity, corporate networks must evolve to stay ahead of risks. For most organizations, this means that DIY security is a thing of the past. That is probably a good thing, since no single security team can hope to ward off a world of threats that range from ransomware to DDoS attacks to critical infrastructure attacks.

Fortunately, your security team does not have to go it alone. For organizations already invested in Microsoft platforms and technologies, the shortest path to full-spectrum protection is to find a Certified Microsoft

Security Partner who can help you deploy and manage Microsoft’s full range of leading security protections. Microsoft Security is now the leader in five Gartner Magic Quadrants, including access management, endpoint management tools, cloud access, enterprise information archiving, and endpoint protection platforms, and with the right partner, your organizations can quickly deploy the tools that are pushing the envelope on threat detection and mitigation, including Microsoft 365 Defender, Microsoft Defender for Endpoint, and Microsoft Azure Sentinel.

With MDR from Difenda, your organization will be protected by the full range of Microsoft’s cutting-edge security tools, while also enjoying such benefits as 24x7x365 accessibility, a single portal to access all threat information, and automated remediation. MDR from Difenda goes beyond basic threat profiling and classification to detect all threats (known and zero-day), while our security experts also actively hunt new threats.

Your organization can maximize its Microsoft investments, while also accumulating additional benefits, such as simplified compliance and increased efficiencies through automation with MDR from Difenda.

With Difenda and Microsoft, your company will be automatically protected by the latest defense strategies, so you can spend your time running your business instead of running in fear.

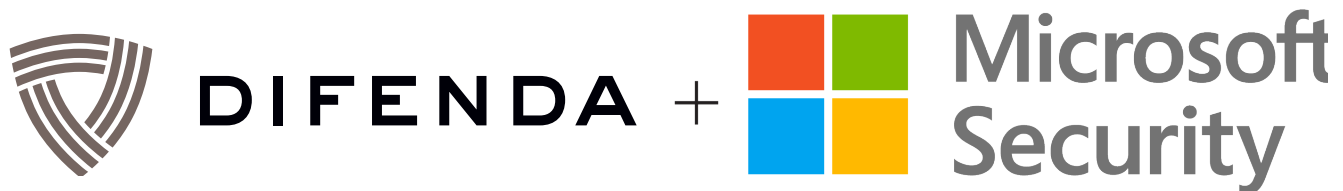
Find out all of the ways Difenda will protect your organization, while also maximizing your investment in Microsoft, by scheduling a product demo today!

Difenda & Microsoft Security - Simplify Cybersecurity: 5 Step Roadmap

If your organization experiences too much complexity, this leads to concerning cyber risks. Difenda & Microsoft can help you invest in a cyber-ready foundation built for tomorrow.

Microsoft Security Roadmap Engagement Model





Need help fully maximizing your Microsoft Security ROI?

[Talk with an expert today.](#)